Therefore, as the defender of the Christian faith, it fell within the scope of his prerogative to relax this ‘normal rule’ for his subjects or a for a class of them if he so deemed fit, and only such beneficiaries of the relaxation would be allowed to trade with the ‘enemy’, that is, the infidel.[9] It was not permissible for other subjects to trade with the enemy unless they were directly permitted by the King or were licensed to do so by the Company. Therefore, for all practical purposes, the Charter issued in favour of the Company had a distinct and express Christian colonial character, since it was bound by such rules of conduct regarding commerce with ‘infidels’[10] that were consistent with those of the Christian faith.[11]

However, in the following years, there was a marked increase in the chorus of English traders who expressed serious displeasure at the exclusive munificence enjoyed by the Company. This, coupled with the Company’s own arrogant attitude, led to the House of Commons passing a resolution to the effect that ‘all the subjects of England have equal right to trade to the East Indies unless prohibited by Act of Parliament’, which strengthened the position of the opponents of the Company. To cut a long story short, the opponents managed to secure permission for the establishment of a parallel company through the Charter of 5 September 1698, by the name of ‘English Company Trading to the East Indies’[12], despite the existence of the earlier Charter in favour of the original entity. However, the original Company became the single largest shareholder in the new company and leveraged this position to negotiate terms of coexistence with the new one. These terms were captured in a tripartite agreement entered into by the two entities and the Queen in July 1702. Under this agreement, the original company would surrender its exclusive rights by 1709, until which time both companies would trade in the name of the new amalgamated entity, renamed ‘The United Company of Merchants of England Trading to the East Indies’, whose affairs would be run jointly by representatives of both. The new entity would operate under the Charter of September 1698 for the remainder of the Charter’s term. Thenceforth, all royal charters would be issued to the United Company, which became the new East India Company. Therefore, all references to the Company hereinafter are references to this entity.

For the purposes of the discussion here, the Charter of September 1698 is an important document, since it took forward the colonial evangelical intent of both the Company and the British Parliament in a limited yet concrete